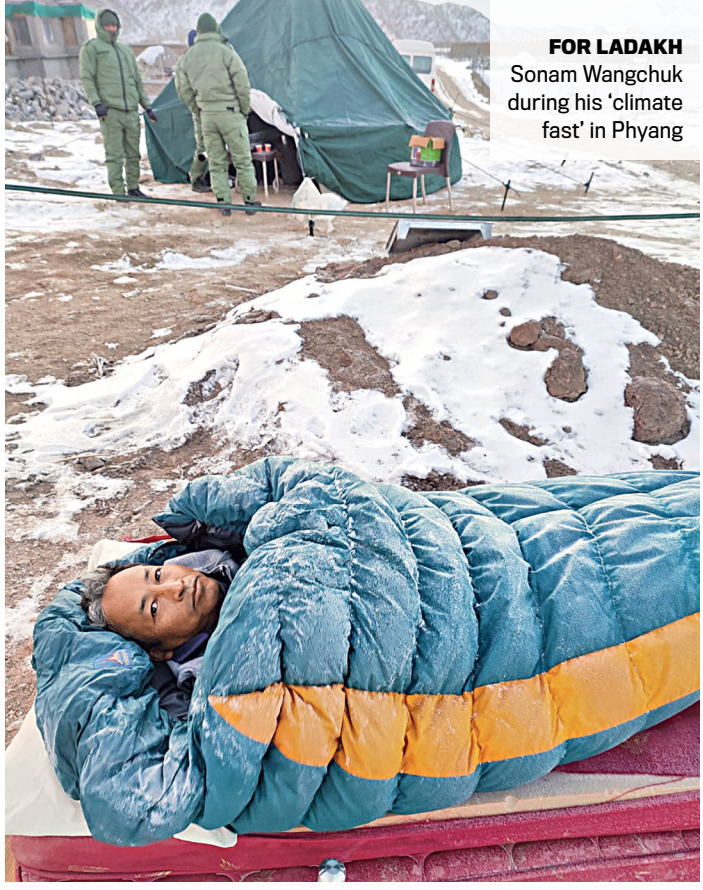


FOR LADAKH
Sonam Wangchuk during his 'climate fast' in Phyang

CALL OF CHANGE FROM NORTH



Wangchuk isn't the only one demanding change. It has united disparate sections in Leh, Kargil

- Sparsely populated Ladakh has a total area of 59,146 sq. km, greater than Himachal Pradesh or Punjab
- Over 90 per cent of its population comprises indigenous tribes
- UT status for Ladakh was a long-pending demand, but after the abrogation of Article 370, people feel the need for a legislature
- Leh and Kargil districts have united to press for a set of demands: full-fledged statehood, safeguards under Sixth Schedule, job reservation for youth, establishment of Public Service Commission and one more Lok Sabha constituency
- There is growing concern about ecological damage, with reports that glaciers are melting due to commercial activity

with China and Pakistan and home to 270,000 people. Ladakh, comprising the districts of Leh and Kargil, has been promised inclusion under the Sixth Schedule several times by the Centre. It's now pressing for that status—currently granted only to Assam, Mizoram, Meghalaya and Tripura—to ensure local control and protection of land, livelihood and environment.

The schedule allows the setting up of autonomous district councils in tribal areas with legislative and administrative autonomy. Though Leh and Kargil have been administered by autonomous hill development councils since 1995, their powers would increase if granted the status. From being empowered to make laws on land, forests and trade, a Sixth Schedule inclusion would also enable the councils control over property, markets, education, taxation and mining activities.

Only an area with a tribal population of 50 per cent or above is entitled to apply for the Sixth Schedule. Ladakh, with its Balti, Beda, Bot, Boto, Brokpa, Drokpa, Dard, Shin, Changpa, Garra, Mon and Purigpa tribes forming 90-plus per cent of its population, is thus eminently suited for the status. On September 11, 2019, the National Commission for Scheduled Tribes led by Dr Nand Kumar Sai duly recommended the inclusion of Ladakh in the Sixth Schedule. A year later, in its manifesto for the Ladakh Autonomous Hill Development Council (LAHDC) election in October 2020, the BJP too promised constitutional safeguards for Ladakh under the schedule.

"POLITICIANS SOMETIMES TAKE DECISIONS THAT CAN TURN *VIKAAS* INTO *VINAASH*. WE WANT PROTECTION OF OUR REGION UNDER THE SIXTH SCHEDULE"

SONAM WANGCHUK
Education reformist, innovator

That tack, however, was to change soon without so much as a by-your-leave. The Union home ministry told a parliamentary standing committee last year that "the main objective for inclusion of tribal population under fifth/sixth schedule is to ensure their overall socio-economic development", and that "the UT administration in Ladakh has been taking care of since its creation".

The U-turn has created a general dismay among locals—including in Kargil, which with its Shia Muslim population finds itself in uneasy cohabitation with Buddhist Leh—and Wangchuk is proving a rallying point for the dissenters. The innovator, on whom Aamir Khan's character in *3 Idiots* was based, had initially been an enthusiastic supporter of UT status. But the locals feel the reality of disempowerment under direct central rule so acutely that he now concedes, "I never wanted to say this, but I have to say we were better off in Jammu and Kashmir." Wangchuk, predicting a phase of reckless exploitation of local resources for mining and hydel power, says: "Politicians sometimes take decisions against climate for development. They turn *vikaas* into *vinaash*."

Not just Ladakh but the entire downstream region depends on water from its Himalayan glaciers, he points out, citing recent studies predicting the extinction of two-thirds of Ladakh's glaciers due to human activity. "Why is reminding you about the Sixth Schedule promise a crime today? Police are